EMPLOYER GUIDE

# Off-the-Job Training: A Guide for Employers

## Why off-the-job training matters

Every apprentice must spend part of their paid working hours on off-the-job (OTJ) training. It is a condition of apprenticeship funding and, more importantly, it is the time that turns a job into a programme of genuine development. Apprentices who get their OTJ time consistently are far more likely to finish on time and achieve a higher grade.

**In short**
Your apprentice's training plan shows their planned OTJ hours — for example 310 hours over a 15-month Data Analyst programme, which is around 5 hours per week. Protecting a regular weekly slot is the single most effective thing a line manager can do.

## What counts as off-the-job training

| Counts | Does not count |
|---|---|
| Delcorn live workshops and recordings | Progress reviews |
| 1:1 coaching with the skills coach | English and maths (Functional Skills) study |
| Online learning modules in Aptiva | Doing their normal job |
| Shadowing colleagues in other teams | Training outside paid hours (without time off in lieu) |
| Stretch projects that build new skills | The end-point assessment itself |
| Writing assignments and reflective journals | Mandatory company training unrelated to the standard |

## How OTJ is recorded

Apprentices record their OTJ in Aptiva, our e-portfolio, at least weekly. Workshop attendance is recorded automatically. The skills coach checks entries every month, and you will see the OTJ position at every 12-weekly progress review. You can view your apprentices' progress at any time through the Aptiva Employer Portal.

## How we rate progress

| Rating | OTJ logged vs expected to date | What we will ask of you |
|---|---|---|
| Green | 92% or more | Keep doing what you're doing |
| Amber | 78% to under 92% | Agree a short catch-up plan with the coach |
| Red | Under 78% | Meet with the coach and delivery manager to protect time and agree a recovery plan |

## What we ask of line managers

1 Agree a regular, protected weekly learning slot with your apprentice and put it in both calendars.

2. Attend the 12-weekly progress review (60 minutes, on Teams). We aim for employer attendance at 90% of reviews.
3. Give the apprentice real workplace projects that let them practise new skills.
4. Sign the review record in Aptiva within 10 working days.
5. Tell the skills coach early about changes — new role, extended leave, redundancy risk or wellbeing concerns.

## Frequently asked questions

### Can OTJ be done in one block rather than weekly?

Yes. Some employers prefer a study day every fortnight or a block week. What matters is that the planned total is reached by the end of the practical period and recorded accurately.

### What if peak season means my apprentice can't take time this month?

Talk to the skills coach before it happens. We can re-profile OTJ around busy periods, but we must agree it in writing and the total cannot reduce.

### What happens if OTJ falls too far behind?

The apprentice is rated Red and we will contact you to agree a recovery plan. If OTJ cannot be released, the apprenticeship may need to be paused or ended, which affects your levy investment.

## Contact

Your apprentice's skills coach is your first point of contact. For anything else, contact the Learning Delivery team at delivery@delcorn.co.uk.